

1. Purpose

Granular Delegated Admin Privileges (GDAP) fundamentally change how Cloud Solution Providers (CSPs) interact with customer tenants by replacing the broad, implicit access model of Delegated Admin Privileges (DAP) with a role-based, least-privilege framework. Although GDAP allows a partner to operate with the permissions of high-privilege roles such as Global Administrator, it does not make the partner identity equivalent to a native Global Administrator account within the customer's Entra ID tenant. This distinction is critical for understanding operational boundaries, security posture, and governance implications.

Under GDAP, a partner administrator is still an external identity authenticated in the partner's home tenant and granted delegated permissions through a time-bound, role-scoped relationship. As a result, certain tenant-level, identity-level, and security-critical operations remain restricted to local Global Administrators - those identities created and managed directly within the customer's directory. These limitations are intentional and reflect Microsoft's security model: delegated access can provide administrative capability, but it cannot override tenant-controlled boundaries, conditional access enforcement, commerce authority, or Azure RBAC ownership.

This document outlines the architectural differences between GDAP-based Global Administrator access and native Global Administrator access, highlights the operational constraints imposed on CSP administrators, and provides what delegated access can and cannot achieve within an end-customer environment.

This document reflects the best information available at the time of creation. It may contain errors or omissions. Please refer to appropriate manufacturer documentation for up-to-date information.

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3. Reference

3.1. Customer Partner Relationships

A CSP provider / reseller cannot manage or view partner relationships using GDAP including:

- Remove or modify the customer's partner relationships
- Remove other partners' GDAP assignments
- View or manage the customer's Partner Admin Link (PAL) associations
- Remove their own partner tenant from the customer's "Partners" blade

A CSP reseller and end user cannot remove a partner relationship if any licenses or subscription are active in the end user tenant.

3.2. Elevated Global Admin

A CSP provider / reseller cannot elevate their own privileges or assign roles to themselves including:

- Assigning themselves additional roles in the customer tenant
- Elevate to Privileged Role Administrator or other roles unless explicitly granted
- Modify their own GDAP assignment
- Enable User Access Administrator

The User Access Administrator role is able to assign themselves to or others 'Owner' rights to Azure subscriptions; therefore, it is restricted to local GA accounts only.

3.3. Modify or Disable Conditional Access Policies

A CSP provider / reseller, using GDAP, can manage CA policies only if their GDAP role includes the necessary permissions and the policy does not block external admins, including:

- Bypass CA policies
- Disable CA policies that block external identities
- Modify CA policies that restrict partner access

3.4. Manage Authentication Methods for External Admins

A CSP provider / reseller cannot:

- Reset their own MFA in the customer tenant. This must be done in the partner's home tenant
- Modify authentication methods for external identities
- Disable MFA enforcement for partner accounts

3.5. Manage Access to Billing and Subscriptions

GDAP never grants:

- Billing Administrator
- Commerce Administrator
- License purchase authority
- Subscription ownership
- Payment method management

- Product key generation permissions

Note: These are related direct subscriptions. CSP subscriptions and billing are managed by the CSP provider outside of the end user tenant.

3.6. Product License Key Generation

Product license key generation is a commerce function that is not available in GDAP. Using GDAP a partner does not have access to:

- Microsoft 365 Admin Center → Billing
- Volume Licensing Service Center (VLSC)
- Microsoft Business Center

Note: A CSP provider (distributor) can generate keys for licenses sold by the provider in Partner Center.

3.7. Manage Azure Resources without Explicit RBAC

GDAP only applied to Entra ID, it does not directly affect Azure subscriptions. Additionally, since GDAP does not support Elevated Global Admin, a subscription 'Owner' must explicitly grant access to subscription.

GDAP does not support:

- Access Azure Resource Manager
- Assign Azure RBAC roles
- Manage subscriptions or resource groups
- View or modify Azure policies

3.8. Modify Directory-Level Settings Related to External Admins

If a setting affects a partner's access, the partner may not modify them using GDAP, including:

- External collaboration settings
- Cross-tenant access settings
- Restrictions on external admins
- Tenant-level security defaults

3.9. Modify Certain Security or Compliance Features

Unless explicitly granted via GDAP roles, a partner cannot:

- Access Purview compliance portals
- Manage eDiscovery cases
- Access Customer Key or Double Key Encryption
- Modify tenant-wide security baselines

4. Associated Documents

- [Granular delegated admin privileges \(GDAP\) introduction - Partner Center | Microsoft Learn](#)
- [GDAP role guidance - Partner Center | Microsoft Learn](#)
- [Workloads supported by granular delegated admin privileges - Partner Center | Microsoft Learn](#)
- [GDAP frequently asked questions - Partner Center | Microsoft Learn](#)

5. Document Approval

This document has been approved by:

- Manager, Cloud Sales Engineering

6. Document Revision History

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1.0	2/9/2026	Initial Draft	David Bloom

GDAP Limitations



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7. Appendix A – Comparison Chart

Capability Area	GDAP Global Admin (External CSP)	Native Tenant Global Admin (Local Account)
Partner Relationship Management	Cannot remove partners, modify GDAP/DAP, or manage PAL	Full control over partner relationships
Role Assignment to Self	Cannot self-assign roles or elevate privileges	Can assign themselves any role
Conditional Access Policies	Can manage CA only if not blocked by CA policies affecting external users	Full control, can disable or override any CA policy
Authentication Methods (External Identities)	Cannot reset MFA or modify auth methods for external accounts	Full control over all authentication methods
Billing & Commerce	No access to billing, subscriptions, payment methods	Full access to billing and commerce
Azure Resource Manager (ARM)	No Azure RBAC unless explicitly granted by customer	Full Azure access; can elevate to User Access Administrator
Tenant-Level Security Settings	Cannot override external collaboration restrictions or cross-tenant access settings	Full control over all tenant-level settings
Security & Compliance (Purview)	Only if explicitly granted via GDAP roles	Can self-assign and access all compliance features
Break-Glass / Emergency Access	Cannot manage or modify break-glass accounts	Full control
Directory-Wide Settings	Limited; cannot override restrictions on external admins	Full control
Self-Service Privilege Elevation	Not allowed	Allowed
Access to All Admin Portals	Only portals tied to roles granted via GDAP	Full access to all portals